



CRUSADER: Meshram at the sammelan in Achhnera

Setting A Woman's Agenda

The administration brings together *saas* and *bahu* in a mission for hygiene and empowerment

■ By Shyam Lal Yadav

Ravindree looks towards her mother-in-law Premvati when she is asked, "Do you quarrel with your mother-in-law?" They deny having ever fought with each other ever and then move on to the other problems they have come to resolve. This is a "*saas-bahu sammelan*" (mother-in-law—daughter-in-law meeting) being held at the block headquarters at Achhnera town in Agra district.

Over 2,000 women, who assembled at the *sammelan*, were told about government schemes pertaining to women which included immunisation and contraceptive programmes as well as the domestic violence act. Between May and October, 32 dowry deaths were reported in Agra district along with 167 cases of harassment against women. The two main objectives of the *sammelan* were to reduce tensions within the family and to address the menace of dowry.

There were some fun elements amid serious talks. Several competitions such as tug-of-war, *matka phod* (breaking a pot) and a healthy baby show were held among the women. In a district, where the literacy rate among women is less than 40 per cent, such programme may set off winds of change.



The event was organised by the Agra district administration under District Magistrate Mukesh Meshram, the 20th such event during Meshram's tenure. He senses its impact. "People from villages now come to the development officers for advice," he says.

The advice sought is of many kinds: from how to dispel tensions at home, as well as how to address the lack of proper toilets for women in the region. It is an issue the men may snigger at, but the women have been most vocal. In Agra district there are around 3.57 lakh families in rural areas but only 1.97 of them have any type of toilets of which less than 50 per cent are operational. "People talk about *izzat* (dignity) but without a toilet for ladies, it's meaningless," says Anandi, a housewife from Garhi Ma village. "The absence of toilet is the main reason of all diseases among women," says Garima Yadav, sub-divisional magistrate of Achhnera.

A competition has been instituted for the construction of toilets among richer families which would further benefit the 30 per cent of families below poverty line in the district. The cost of construction for a single toilet is Rs 3,000, of which Rs 1,500 is being offered by the Government as subsidy. The *sammelan* is able to help the women of a small part of the country set their own agenda for change. ■